

Last Minute Learning: Academic Procrastination among Undergraduate Students

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ABSTRACT

Academic procrastination is very concerning problem among university students which negatively affects mental well-being, academic performance and timely graduation. The research aims to identify the level of academic procrastination among AIUB undergraduate students and examine the relationship between self-efficacy and procrastination. Primary data were collected via google form using structured close-ended questionnaire distribution which are associated with procrastination and self-efficacy scales. The collected data from 121 AIUB undergraduates were analyzed using descriptive statistics and Pearson's correlations in R programming. Descriptive statistics showed that most students belong to moderate level to high level of procrastination, where living environments showing noticeable impact and gender differences stayed minimal. Besides, correlation was very weak and statistically insignificant relationship between self-efficacy and academic procrastination. These findings suggest educators, academic advisors and institutional policymakers to design effective academic curriculum and evidence-based interventions to reduce academic procrastination and give better academic environment for better outcomes.

Keywords: Delaying Task, Self-efficacy, Positivist, Pearsons' correlation, AIUB.

INTRODUCTION

Problem Background

Academic procrastination is a common problem among university students. It means delaying academic work such as studying for exams, completing assignments, or writing reports, even when students know it can harm their performance (Kim & Seo, 2020). Another key concept in this study is academic self-efficacy, which means how confident students feel about their ability to plan and complete academic tasks successfully (Hayat et al., 2024). Research shows that procrastination is not only caused by poor time management, it is also influenced by motivation, emotions, and thinking patterns. Students with low academic confidence are more likely to procrastinate (Sirois & Pychyl, 2023).



Figure 1: Facebook post

Academic procrastination is a common issue among American International University-Bangladesh (AIUB) students. For example, a student shared on the AIUB COURSE SOLUTION Facebook group that she planned to start studying for a midterm exam one week earlier but delayed until the night before. This caused high stress, poor memory of the content, and a low exam score. Studies show that students procrastinate because of fear of failure, stress, thinking tasks are too difficult, or believing they can finish everything at the last moment (Rabin et al., 2020). Research after the COVID-19 pandemic also shows that procrastination has increased among university students and has negatively affected their academic performance, mental health, and self-control (Sirois & Pychyl, 2023). This problem affects students from all departments at AIUB, including engineering, business, life science, and social science.

Although academic procrastination has been widely studied, no research focuses on AIUB undergraduate students. This study aims to fill some important gaps: the level of academic procrastination among AIUB undergraduates has not been measured, and the relationship between academic self-efficacy and procrastination among these students remains unclear. Understanding these gaps can help develop effective learning strategies and provide better academic support to improve students' performance at AIUB.

Related Studies & Research Gap

Academic procrastination has been examined in previous studies from multiple contextual and theoretical points of view. Research has highlighted that the delay behavior is associated with psychological, personal and pedagogical dimensions (Salguero-Pazos et al., 2023). Scholars have defined self-regulation as a bundle of cognitive and metacognitive skills which are closely connected with procrastination, especially when a student struggles to plan, monitor and control their learning (Elizondo et al., 2024). Some researchers found that the role of fear and some other self-regulation factors in academic procrastination. Those who are afraid are more likely to delay tasks, which means when their self-regulatory capabilities are weak (Abdi Zarrin et al., 2020). To explain procrastination, combination of multiple explanatory approaches is better than focusing on single factors. Such studies have shown that time and effort management skills, psychological flexibility and academic self-efficacy play a bigger role in procrastination than academic self-efficacy alone (Hailikari et al., 2021). Additionally, procrastination friendly academic environment such as flexible deadlines, limited external monitoring may unintentionally drive the students to postpone tasks (Svartdal et al., 2020). Altogether, these findings help to understand the factors behind procrastination.

These studies are closely related to our research because of theoretical and empirical investigation, why students procrastinate, which psychological factors are involved and how they procrastinate. Related studies have shown the cause and effect of procrastination. But still, there are some gaps:

- Several studies show negative ($-.54$) relationship between academic self-efficacy and procrastination (Elizondo et al., 2024), while others find weak or no relation (Hailikari et al., 2021).
- Most of the studies on academic procrastination have been conducted in a specific region or universities (University of Isfahan in Iran) (Abdi Zarrin et al., 2020).

Research Objectives & RQs

Academic procrastination negatively affects students' academic performance and may later reduce workplace quality and responsibility across different professions. From an economic perspective, procrastination can lead to poor academic results and delayed graduation, which increases educational costs. Socially, it is associated with higher levels of stress and anxiety and lower academic engagement. From a sustainability perspective, reducing procrastination supports the efficient use of educational resources, improves student well-being, and improves self-regulation.

Based on these gaps, the objectives of this study are:

- To measure the level of academic procrastination among AIUB undergraduate students.
- To examine the relationship between academic procrastination and academic self-efficacy among AIUB undergraduate students.

Research Questions:

1. What is the level of academic procrastination among AIUB undergraduate students?
2. What is the relationship between academic procrastination and academic self-efficacy among AIUB undergraduate students?

Research Contributions

By identifying the level of academic procrastination among AIUB undergraduate students, this study provides AIUB-specific data and helps teachers and counselors understand the seriousness of the problem. Examining the relationship between academic procrastination and academic self-efficacy also helps clarify mixed findings from previous research. These results can support the development of effective interventions, improve time management and learning strategies, and reduce academic stress across different disciplines at AIUB.

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

Selection of Data Collection method

This study used a survey method to collect data from AIUB undergraduate students. A structured questionnaire (close-ended) was distributed through Google Forms to collect data efficiently. The questionnaire included the Student's Academic Procrastination Scale (Solomon & Rothblum, 1984) and an academic self-efficacy scale developed (Bashir, 2019) Data were analyzed using the R programming language. Descriptive statistics were used to determine the level of academic procrastination, and correlation analysis was conducted to examine the relationship between procrastination and academic self-efficacy. The survey method was chosen because the research questions require numerical data. Google Forms is cost-effective, reduces data entry errors, and makes participation convenient for students. Since no existing data set focuses on AIUB undergraduate students, primary data collection was necessary. Interviews and observations were not used because they are time-consuming and not suitable for statistical analysis. Although a literature review supported the study, it could not provide AIUB-specific data on its own. This research follows a positivist approach, which focuses on objective measurement and numerical data. Since the study uses structured surveys and statistical analysis to examine relationships between variables, the positivist approach is appropriate for this research.

Description of the Data Collection Method

Based on extensive literature reviews of relevant articles on academic procrastination, self-regulation and academic self-efficacy the questionnaire was developed. Commonly reported factors and behavioral patterns were observed which are related to procrastination. After that the selected questionnaire was finalized for collecting data which are strongly aligned with the research objectives of this study. We have made sure that the research questions are aligned with the research objectives by doing systematically mapping each item to verify the key structure such as level of procrastination, academic self-efficacy and strategies to decrease procrastination were covered without redundancy. Irrelevant items were excluded from the questionnaire. The data were collected through questionnaires in form of students' academic procrastination and self-efficacy.

Section 1 (Demographics): 1) What is your gender? 2) Current semester? 3) Where do you live?

Section 2 (Academic Procrastination Scale): How much do you agree with the following statements: i) I postpone starting academic tasks (assignments, projects, or study) until the deadline is very close. ii) I delay studying for quizzes or exams even when I have enough time earlier. iii) I often rush to complete academic work at the last moment. iv) I avoid starting academic tasks that I find difficult, boring, or stressful. v) I leave important parts of my academic work (such as revision, editing, or checking) until the very end.

Section 3 (Academic Self-Efficacy Scale): How confident do you feel about each statement: i) I am confident that I can understand and learn most academic concepts taught in my courses. ii) I can complete academic assignments or projects successfully if I put in enough effort. iii) I am confident in managing my time to meet academic deadlines. iv) I feel confident preparing for quizzes, exams, or evaluations using my own study plan.

The survey was conducted through online google form distribution. As our research scope is based on AIUB students, data was collected from only AIUB students. The total number of participants was 121. To submit data each participant must answer all the questions provided in google form. Data was exported from google form to excel file and analyzed using statistical software. We used likert scale method to convert the chosen data of questions into numeric form for descriptive analysis. This analysis such as frequencies, and percentage was used to understand and summarize the data. Correlation methods were introduced to identify the correlation between self-efficacy and student procrastination. This data was presented visually using tables, graphs, charts etc. for easy identification.

Ethical Standards of Engineering Practice

This study strictly followed ethical standards. Established and reliable scales were used to ensure data authenticity. Data were collected from AIUB undergraduate students through Google Forms between 1 December 2025 and 15 December 2025. Participation was voluntary, and students were informed about the purpose of the study before responding. No personal or identifiable information was collected, no incentives were offered, and duplicate responses were removed to maintain data integrity. Automatic data recording through Google Forms reduced the risk of manipulation. The study focuses on measuring academic procrastination and examining its relationship with academic self-efficacy without labeling or judging students. From social, economic, and sustainability perspectives, the findings can support better academic assistance, reduce delayed graduation, and encourage responsible learning behavior. Overall, the research follows ethical

engineering practices by protecting participants, ensuring reliable data, and contributing to sustainable educational improvement.

RESULTS AND ANALYSIS

Research Data/Results

The findings indicate that academic procrastination is a common behavior among AIUB undergraduate students, where most of the students reported moderate to high levels of procrastination. The observation was based on living place, where students living away from family, especially in mess accommodations are more likely to show higher procrastination levels compared to those living with their families. In addition, gender-based differences were minimal, which suggest that academic procrastination affects male and female students in a similar manner. Overall, the results highlight the influence of living environment on procrastination behavior while indicating limited gender variation.

Distribution of Academic Procrastination Levels
Among AIUB Undergraduate Students

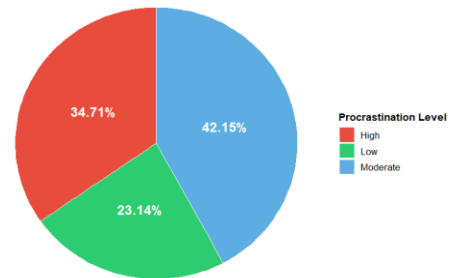


Figure 2: Academic procrastination levels

Table 1: Procrastination Level based on Living place

Living vs Level	Hostel	Mess	With family
High	25%	41.94%	28.21%
Moderate	35%	43.55%	43.59%
Low	40%	14.52%	28.21%

Table 2: Procrastination Level based on Gender

Level vs Gender	High	Moderate	Low
Male	34.88%	44.19%	20.93%
Female	34.28%	37.14%	28.57%

To understand the relationship between academic procrastination and academic self-efficacy, Pearson's correlation analysis was performed using the survey data. The analysis found a correlation coefficient of $r = 0.06$ which indicates a very weak and statistically insignificant relationship between the two variables. This result suggests that levels of academic self-efficacy do not meaningfully predict academic procrastination behavior among AIUB undergraduate students.

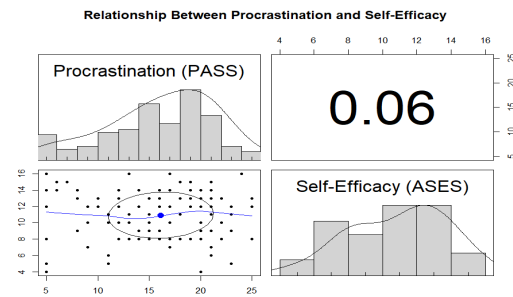


Figure 3: Pearson's correlation analysis

Analysis and Discussion

RQ1: What is the level of academic procrastination among AIUB undergraduate students?

The results show that academic procrastination among AIUB undergraduate students is generally moderate with a significant percentage also exhibiting high procrastination. Students who live in low grade appear to be closer to higher levels of procrastination. On the other hand, those who live with family exhibit somewhat lower and more balanced levels. There were very few gender-based differences which suggest that procrastination and gender are not closely related in this situation.

RQ2: Is there a significant correlation between academic procrastination and academic self-efficacy among AIUB undergraduate students?

The results confirm that there is no significant correlation between academic procrastination and academic self-efficacy among AIUB undergraduate students. This finding suggests that academic procrastination is influenced by factors beyond self-efficacy, such as environmental conditions, academic workload, and self-regulatory skills.

Therefore, rather than concentrating only on increasing self-efficacy, procrastination reduction programs should include a multimodal approach. Since flexible deadlines and little external monitoring frequently result in "procrastination-friendly" learning environments, academic and instructional practices can be improved by implementing structured deadlines, staged assignments, frequent progress checks, and clear task instructions. Additionally, teaching pupils academic skills and study techniques like self-monitoring, metacognitive awareness, pomodoro technique, one minute rule, and reflective learning might improve their task management.

Solution Validation

The validity of the research findings was ensured through several approaches. First, the survey-based results were compared with existing literature, which identifies academic procrastination as a widespread issue among university students and reports mixed findings regarding its relationship with self-efficacy (Steel, 2007). Second, the statistical analysis, particularly the low Pearson correlation coefficient ($r = 0.06$), supports the internal consistency and logical validity of the findings. Third, procrastination friendly learning environment, academic and instructional practice were introduced in a study (Svartdal et al., 2020). Along with this academic study techniques were also introduced in another study (Zimmerman, 2000; Shekholeslami, 2017). Finally, the results have practical relevance, as they can be applied within the AIUB academic setting to design evidence-based approaches focusing on time management, structured academic support, and improved learning environments.

CONCLUSION

Concluding remarks

This study shows that most AIUB undergraduate students experience moderate to high levels of academic procrastination. The results show that academic procrastination is not substantially correlated with academic self-efficacy, indicating that this behavior is influenced by a variety of environmental and self-regulatory factors. All things considered, the study emphasizes the necessity of comprehensive, skill-based, and instructional interventions to successfully lower academic procrastination and promote students' academic achievement.

Limitation

The data collection was only one point at a time, which shows relationships between variables, but cannot identify which causes the other. Data collection through google form may get biased data. Furthermore, the study only included undergraduate students from AIUB, which would restrict how broadly the results can be applied to other institutions or situations.

Future scope

To effectively investigate the causal linkages between procrastination and its associated factors, future research should use longitudinal methods. Generalizability would be enhanced by broadening the sample to include a variety of academic areas and institutions. In addition to assessing the efficacy of focused intervention programs, future study may examine other factors such self-regulation, time management abilities, mental health, and academic environment.

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